

Winners and Losers

Fresh from his victory in the state polls, Gujarat's Narendra Modi finds pan-Indian acceptance as voters across the country choose him as the best chief minister

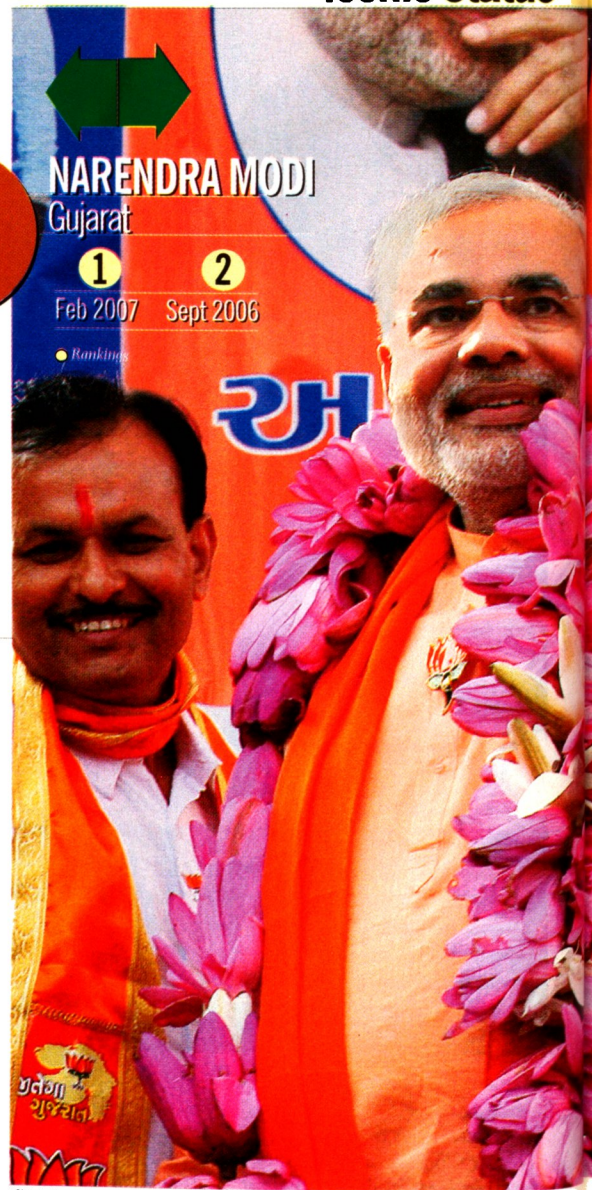
Iconic Status

■ By Ashok K. Damodaran

Narendra Modi was not the chief minister of Gujarat when in August 2001, INDIA TODAY and pollsters AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG broadened the scope of the Mood of the Nation Poll to gauge the performance of the country's chief ministers, to see who among them, in public perception, were the best performers and who were the laggards. Two months later in October 2001, Modi replaced Keshubhai Patel as the state chief minister, courted much controversy, won two elections and has since then stayed on in office. In our first poll since he rose to power, Modi was voted the fifth best chief minister by voters across the country and he moved up to the third spot in our subsequent exercise six months later. He has stayed in the top three in the many polls since then, for long terms occupying the top slot, yielding occasionally only to bounce back.

Our last poll was conducted a year ago where Modi shared the top slot with his good friend, Nitish Kumar of Bihar. Our current poll, conducted just a month after he was

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Change of Guard

A strong wave against incumbents in some of the poll-bound states points to voter dissatisfaction with their respective state governments. This could be a pointer to a possible change in the power structure after the assembly elections later this year and a barometer for electoral fortunes in the Lok Sabha polls next year.

